on the rear bench. We stopped for the night at various locations en route such as Batote, Ramban and Quazigund; places where there were recovery posts established by Dad's unit. Batote can be quite cold on a rainy day, which was the case when we halted for the night.

This was one of the first occasions when we had a tot of rum mixed in our milk, a 'night cap' to keep our body temperature above the freezing point. We had four army blankets over us, which were of such a rough texture that it hurt our skin. We used our handkerchiefs to cover our faces and soon went off to sleep. It must have been the tranquillizer effect of the army rum! Later on, during my military career, our civilian friends would often request us to serve them canteen rum. The most common pretext was that the army rum had more 'dum' (punch) than what was available in the market. It was a gift that was universally accepted and appreciated.

Our journey up to Srinagar, though interesting, was quite uneventful. J&K was a peaceful state in those carefree days. One could pick up fruits like peaches, plums or apples from the trees and eat them with relish and saunter about with gay abandon. The Kashmiris looked content and we felt welcomed.

The second trip was *en famille*. During this summer holiday, we travelled in a military convoy from Jammu and stayed in transit camps for the night halts. We reached Srinagar on the third day. My father had hired a house in downtown Srinagar, which we made into a temporary home – it was furnished to minimalistic standards and old newspapers served as curtains. This modest abode became our 'firm base', so to say. Such an arrangement would be quite unthinkable in the present times!

We used to go for long walks and covered all the tourist spots in Srinagar, including the Dal Lake, the Char Chinar island, and the wonderous Mughal Gardens – Shalimar, Nishat and Chashma-Shahi – and the Shankaracharya Temple. The town was one-third the size of what it is today. The mode of travel of the common people was the bus or 'tonga'. The visits to Kokernag and Verinag, the source of the Jhelum, were unforgettable. We saw hundreds of trout in the crystal-clear spring water, including the rarely found rainbow trout.